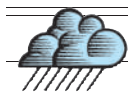


The Washington Post

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Rain 74/51 • Tomorrow: Sunny, breezy 67/48 **B16**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 8, 2025 • \$4

Combative Bondi is pressed on her record

She sidesteps questions on Epstein, Comey amid charges of weaponization

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK

A defiant Attorney General Pam Bondi eagerly clashed with Democrats in a Senate oversight hearing Tuesday, as she defended her record against accusations she has weaponized the Justice Department to shield President Donald Trump's allies and target his foes.

Testifying before the Senate Judiciary Committee, Bondi countered that her predecessors in the Biden administration had politicized the agency first. She touted her efforts in eight months in office to refocus federal law enforcement on combating illegal immigration and violent crime.

She repeatedly dodged questions on pressing issues — such as the department's decision to prosecute former FBI Director James B. Comey, its review of its case files on convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, and a now shuttered FBI bribery investigation into Trump's border czar Tom Homan.

And again and again through almost five hours of exchanges, she lashed out at committee Democrats, responding to their questions with personalized, non sequitur attacks.

"Don't you ever challenge my integrity," Bondi responded to questions over whether she had improperly let Trump influence the department's decisions. "I have abided by every ethical standard. Do not question my ability to be fair and impartial as attorney general."

Tuesday's oversight hearing, Bondi's first appearance before the Judiciary Committee since her confirmation hearing in January, came at a contentious moment.

SEE **BONDI** ON **A4**

Cities largely defy Trump on 'sanctuary' protections

BY DAVID NAKAMURA

As President Donald Trump moves to deploy National Guard troops and federal immigration officers to cities with "sanctuary" or pro-immigrant policies, Democratic leaders in Chicago and elsewhere are responding with their own message: We will not capitulate.

Since taking office, the Trump administration has sued 14 jurisdictions, threatened criminal charges against local officials who do not comply with federal demands, conducted large-scale immigration operations and deployed troops over the objection of mayors and governors.

Just two jurisdictions — Louisville and the state of Nevada — have agreed to drop key policies that had restricted police and sheriffs from assisting U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers in making arrests. And Trump has faced a string of losses in court. A federal judge on Sunday blocked the president's plan to send troops to Portland, Oregon, and leaders in Illinois filed a similar lawsuit Monday to block Trump's attempt to deploy soldiers to Chicago.

"We will not tolerate ICE

SEE **SANCTUARY CITIES** ON **A6**

In solemn memorials, Israelis mark two years since Oct. 7 attacks



PHOTOS BY HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST



Above, residents of Kibbutz Kfar Aza in southern Israel take part in a memorial service starting at dawn Tuesday to honor relatives killed two years ago in the Hamas-led attacks on Oct. 7, 2023. At left, a large plume of smoke across the border in the Gaza Strip is seen from just a few miles away in Kfar Aza, as airstrikes continued in the enclave.

U.S. intervenes to aid woman's rescue from Gaza

Secret operation involving Israel and Jordan ferried mother of U.S. service member out of the enclave

BY HOPE HODGE SECK AND ADAM TAYLOR

A Palestinian woman whose son serves in the U.S. Navy was secretly evacuated from war-torn Gaza in recent weeks after an intervention by the Trump administration and the Israeli and Jordanian governments, according to people familiar with the matter and correspondence re-

viewed by The Washington Post.

The operation, entailing a coordinated pause in Israeli military strikes to safeguard the woman's movements, illustrates the extreme difficulty of orchestrating a legal exit from the Gaza Strip without resources and influence. The unusual operation occurred as the Trump administration has, at turns, been accused of turning a blind eye to the suffering of Pales-

tinians in Gaza — even, in some cases, when they are U.S. citizens.

For Ahlam Firwana, 59, the escape to safety required a \$10,000 donation to cover transportation costs, sophisticated software to monitor her movements amid the Israeli military's ongoing assault, and the direct involvement of senior U.S. officials who helped secure agreements from the governments of

Jordan and Israel to facilitate the woman's departure from Gaza.

Firwana's son, Navy Petty Officer Younis Firwana, 32, joined the military in 2023 seeking a path to U.S. citizenship. After the Gaza war began that October, his mother and six siblings faced ever-increasing danger and privation, he recalled in an interview. In 2024, the family's seven-story

SEE **GAZA** ON **A10**

In Europe, high quality of life is becoming unbearably expensive

France's political crisis deepens as it struggles to afford social spending

BY ANNABELLE TIMSIT, ANTHONY FAIOLA AND AARON WIENER

PARIS — Across Europe, and especially in France, the bill is coming due.

The cost of a signature brand of humanist economics — the so-called European way of life, offering health care, affordable education and a dignified retirement to all, through high social spending — is becoming unbearably high.

In France, as the nation's debt soars, its credit rating slips, incomes stagnate, prime ministers fall and the country stumbles into ungovernability, the public is

grappling with two questions: Will millennials and younger generations lead worse-off lives than their parents and grandparents? And if not, who will pay for the continued comforts?

On Monday, these questions became even more pressing with the stunning resignation of Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu after just four weeks, plunging the country further into political crisis.

"This is the last stop before the cliff," Lecornu's predecessor, Prime Minister François Bayrou, had said before he was ousted last month by lawmakers after presenting a budget that would have required deep cuts, including eliminating two national holidays.

Related challenges loom in neighboring Germany, where the economy is flat after two consecutive years of decline, companies

SEE **EUROPE** ON **A12**



NICK WASS/ASSOCIATED PRESS

No. 8 is back on the ice

NHL all-time goals leader Alex Ovechkin, 40, will begin his 21st season with the Capitals on Wednesday night. **Sports, B7**

THE ECONOMY
U.S.-based TikTok

posters still show overwhelming support for Palestinians as the war rages on in Gaza, a new report found. **A13**

In a sign of economic uncertainty amid trade and geopolitical tensions, gold surged past \$4,000 per ounce. **A13**

STYLE

A documentary about Ellen Greenberg's death gives columnist Monica Hesse an idea as to why we stream so much true crime. **B1**

SPORTS

LeBron James's latest Decision — a pitch for cognac — shows how unserious he is now. **B7**

THE REGION

A D.C. teacher aide was placed on leave after allegedly putting hot sauce in an autistic boy's mouth. **B13**

FOOD

The Ojibwe people are fighting to preserve wild rice and the extraordinary traditions that surround it in Wisconsin. **E1**

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Conversion therapy law Supreme Court justices seemed to sympathize with a therapist who says Colorado's ban on the practice violates her free-speech rights. **A3**

Nobel in physics Three scientists shared the prize for their work in quantum mechanics, a theory ubiquitous in modern technology. **A2**

THE NATION

GOP lawmakers in Utah adopted a Republican-leaning congressional map this week, diminishing Democrats' hopes of gaining a House seat in the conservative state. **A2**

THE WORLD

A rightward tilt is overtaking South American democracies helmed by leftist leaders. **A11**
A Berlin park fills with people drawn by a social media trend: eating pudding with a fork. **A11**